The Verdict of the People: US Elections, Representation and the Americas

English · Première générale · LVA · official target B1+, towards B2 · Seven lessons of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes.

Student sheet: documents, exercises with answer keys, vocabulary, flashcard method and assessment grids. Images, links and the listening button are on the website.

The Verdict of the People

US Elections, Representation and the Americas

Road map

Seven lessons of 55 minutes, each timed for 52 minutes. In every lesson: timed steps, a stopping point at minute 44, an 8-minute emergency exit, and three visible outcomes: a written record, participation (every student speaks at least once) and homework for the next lesson.

1. Lesson 1. Reading the Verdict 52 min

   Describe Bingham's painting; separate observation, context and interpretation.

2. Lesson 2. Why Midterms Matter 52 min

   Explain how Congress can limit presidential power; the passive voice with a reason.

3. Lesson 3. Citizens, but Equally Represented? 52 min

   Compare Puerto Rico and Washington, D.C.; although, whereas, despite.

4. Lesson 4. Images, Claims and Reported Speech 52 min

   Stump Speaking, claims and promises; reported speech.

5. Lesson 5. Results: Establish, Date and Qualify 52 min

   Establish, date and qualify the 2026 results from real sources; past simple and present perfect.

6. Lesson 6. Beyond US Borders 52 min

   Trade with Canada and Mexico; fact or hypothesis; conditionals.

7. Lesson 7. The Cross-Border Radio Discussion 52 min

   The eight-minute radio discussion and the individual briefing note.

Also: the assessment page (oral and written grids /20), the flashcards page (method, model cards, blank template) and the teacher notes (level check against the Bulletin officiel, differentiation, checklist).

Level
: Première générale, langue vivante A (LVA). Official end-of-year target: **B1+**. This sequence consolidates independent B1 performance and develops B2-level performance in selected activities, especially source comparison, supported interpretation and qualified argument. B2 is an extension, not a requirement for every student. In the programme, a “+” means that the next level is reached in at least one language activity.

Curriculum
: Official programme: arrêté of 5 May 2025, Bulletin officiel n° 22 of 29 May 2025 (NOR MENE2504621A), annexe 4, Programme d’anglais pour les classes de lycée général et technologique (BO text). In force for Première and Terminale from the 2026 to 2027 school year. Cultural axes for Première: **axe 6**, « Les aires anglophones américaines » (objet d’étude « Porto Rico : le 51e état ? »); **axe 3**, « Art et pouvoir » (« L’art, les artistes et le pouvoir »); supporting link with **axe 2**, « Diversité et inclusion » (the role of political institutions in representation).

Driving question
: How does the verdict of the people distribute power in the United States, and why does it matter beyond its borders?

Lessons
: Seven lessons of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes. Minutes 52 to 55 stay free for collecting work and moving.

Final task
: In groups of four, an eight-minute radio discussion in English for a Canadian student audience: “The Verdict of the People: What Can US Elections Change at Home and Across Borders?”, plus an individual briefing note of 140 to 170 words.

Assessment
: An individual oral grid (/20) and a written briefing-note grid (/20). These are classroom assessments, not an automatic CEFR conversion.

ABOUT THE 2026 RESULTS

The US midterm elections took place on 3 November 2026. This sequence deliberately gives **no** winner, seat total, gain or loss: in Lesson 5, students establish them from dated, identifiable sources, and say clearly what is not yet established. A media call, a reported count and a legal certification are not the same thing.

Your project

You are going to present a student radio programme for young Canadians who know little about US institutions. Starting from a nineteenth-century painting, you will explain how Congress shares power with the president, why Puerto Rico and Washington, D.C. are represented differently, how to report election results honestly, and why Canada and Mexico follow US elections closely.

What you will be able to do

Area	Secure B1+ performance	Towards B2
Visual analysis	Describe details and suggest a supported interpretation.	Compare interpretations and explain their limits.
Reading	Identify the main information and relevant details.	Recognise qualifications; separate claims from evidence.

Area	Secure B1+ performance	Towards B2
Listening	Follow a clearly structured explanation.	Identify the main point and the limits of the explanation.
Speaking	Explain a rule and justify a view.	Respond to a counterargument; clarify an unexpected question.
Writing	Produce connected, organised paragraphs.	Build a nuanced argument with carefully chosen evidence.
Mediation	Explain unfamiliar institutions to another student.	Prevent misleading comparisons; reformulate complex information.

How each lesson works

Participation routine. At the start of every lesson, Partner A speaks for about 20 seconds and Partner B answers for about 20 seconds; they swap when the prompt requires it. The teacher circulates with a participation roster. A quiet exchange with a partner counts; a student who needs support may use a prepared sentence. Whole-class volunteering does not replace this routine.

Learning log, five sections: cultural documents; corrected exercises; written records; source log; vocabulary and flashcard reviews.

Answer keys are printed straight after each exercise, so that students can check their work and catch up alone.

Related sequences on this site. The Capital Trap (Seconde and Première, B1 / B1+) works on the geography of US state capitals and the question “Is the biggest city always the capital?”: it does not cover Congress, elections or representation, which are taught only here. The King Reigns, Parliament Rules studies British institutions: students who know it can compare Parliament and Congress, but nothing from it is repeated in this sequence. Hijacking the Grid (Terminale) looks at New York City through its marathon.

https://itineraires-destinations.fr/the-verdict-of-the-people/

Sources checked

Checked on 11 November 2026 (Europe/Paris).

- Bulletin officiel n° 22 of 29 May 2025, arrêté of 5 May 2025, NOR MENE2504621A, annexe 4 (English, lycée général et technologique).
- Saint Louis Art Museum: The Verdict of the People · The County Election · Stump Speaking. All three: Rights, Public Domain.
- USAGov, Congressional elections and midterm elections · USAGov, state election offices.
- National Archives: the Constitution · Amendments 11 to 27 (Twenty-third Amendment).
- Office of the Resident Commissioner of Puerto Rico, “What is a Resident Commissioner?”
- Office of the US Trade Representative, USMCA (entry into force: 1 July 2020).

Lesson 1. Reading the Verdict

How does Bingham represent popular power and exclusion?

Road map

Lesson of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes. Lesson 1 of 7. Minutes 52 to 55 stay free for collecting work, moving and the change of room.

1. Paired opening: “An election can show people’s power because…” 4 min (minutes 0 to 4)
2. Title, artist and final project 4 min (minutes 4 to 8)
3. Silent observation, then Exercise 1A 7 min (minutes 8 to 15)
4. Read Source A and complete Exercise 1B 8 min (minutes 15 to 23)
5. Correction: visible detail or contextual knowledge? 7 min (minutes 23 to 30)
6. Grammar: describe and qualify, Exercise 1C 6 min (minutes 30 to 36)
7. Main production: evidence table and museum guide, Exercises 1D and 1E 8 min (minutes 36 to 44)
8. Written record 4 min (minutes 44 to 48)
9. Exit ticket: one observation and one interpretation 2 min (minutes 48 to 50)
10. Explain and record homework 2 min (minutes 50 to 52)

- **Written record.** Bingham represents an election result as a public event; we separate what we see, what a source tells us and what we interpret.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: Partner A speaks for about 20 seconds, Partner B answers for about 20 seconds, then they swap during the museum-guide challenge. A quiet exchange with a partner counts; a student who needs support may read a prepared sentence.
- **Homework for next lesson.** Finish the 90 to 110-word museum label, make three flashcards, prepare one question about how election results affect government.

Stopping point. Minute 44, after the paired museum-guide description and the evidence table. Next lesson starts from the label.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If only eight working minutes remain, this replaces the unfinished plan; it is not added to it.

1. Minutes 0 to 2: both partners state one observation.
2. Minutes 2 to 5: write the written record, adding one spatial expression.
3. Minutes 5 to 7: record and restate the homework.
4. Minute 7 to 8: hand in one cautious interpretation on a slip of paper.

Objectives

Describe an image, separate observation from interpretation and support a cautious deduction.

Language: spatial expressions (in the foreground, in the background, on the left), present continuous, may, might, could and must.

SOURCE A

The painting and its context

Reference. George Caleb Bingham, *The Verdict of the People*, 1854 to 1855, oil on canvas, Saint Louis Art Museum, accession 45:2001. Museum record.

Student text, newly written from the museum record.

Bingham was both a painter and a politician. In this painting, a crowd gathers around a courthouse to hear election results. The people react differently: some appear delighted, while others seem disappointed, confused or argumentative.

The painting belongs to a three-part Election Series. In narrative order, the works show campaigning, voting and the announcement of results. However, their production dates do not follow that order: the museum dates *The County Election* to 1852, before *Stump Speaking* (1853 to 1854) and *The Verdict of the People* (1854 to 1855).

The museum connects the women on the balcony and the enslaved African American figure in the left foreground with groups who had no voice in government at that time. It also describes the women as temperance (anti-alcohol) reformers. Their presence raises a question: who belongs to “the people” when some people cannot take part on equal terms?

Words beside the text

Expression	Accessible explanation
narrative order	the order of events in the story
political participation	taking part in political decisions
excluded	not allowed to take part
interpretation	an explanation of what something may mean

Teacher’s clarification: students need to understand that the three dates differ, but they do not need to memorise all three for the language assessment.

EXERCISE 1A

Observation, interpretation or context?

Label each statement. **O**: directly observable. **I**: an interpretation. **C**: contextual information that needs a source.

1. A crowd occupies much of the painting.
2. Bingham was also a politician.
3. The variety of reactions suggests that elections divide opinion.
4. Some figures stand above others.
5. The painting was completed in the nineteenth century.
6. The image celebrates democracy without any criticism.

> **Answer key**
>
> 1. O.
> 2. C.
> 3. I.

4. O.
5. C.
6. I, and too absolute without further support.

EXERCISE 1B

Understanding the source

1. What event brings the crowd together?
2. Put the three stages in narrative order: results, campaign, vote.
3. Why must we separate narrative order from painting dates?
4. Which excluded groups does the museum identify?
5. Explain the question raised by the word “people” in the title.

Answer key

1. The announcement of election results.
2. Campaign, vote, results.
3. The scenes form a logical story, but the paintings were not produced in that order.
4. Women and enslaved African Americans, in the historical setting discussed by the museum.
5. The title suggests collective power, but the image and its context make us ask who was excluded from that collective.

EXERCISE 1C

Grammar: describe and qualify

Complete the sentences.

1. In the foreground, several people _____ together. *(stand, present continuous)*
2. The disappointed-looking figure _____ support the losing side. *(express possibility)*
3. A man is lying on the ground. This _____ mean that he is tired, but the posture alone does not prove it. *(express possibility)*
4. The painting _____ historical information, but it is not a photograph. *(provide, present simple)*
5. Rewrite more cautiously: “The painter definitely wants us to admire every aspect of the election.”

Answer key

1. are standing.
2. may, might or could.
3. may, might or could. Note: the museum record describes this man as “inebriated” (drunk). That is the museum’s interpretation, a piece of context (C), not something the posture alone proves.
4. provides.
5. Possible answer: “The painter may be celebrating democratic participation, although the image also invites questions about exclusion.”

EXERCISE 1D

Museum-guide challenge (pairs)

Partner A: describe two visible details, add one spatial expression, suggest one interpretation.

Partner B: say which statement is an interpretation and ask: “What detail supports that?”

Swap roles. Everyone speaks.

> **Answer key**
>
> Success criteria: two details that can really be seen; one spatial expression used correctly; the interpretation is introduced with may, might, could or suggests; Partner B’s question is answered with a detail.

EXERCISE 1E · MAIN PRODUCTION

Build the evidence, then write the label

Complete the table with a detail of your choice.

Visible detail	Possible interpretation	Limit
People react differently.	The result may divide the crowd.	We cannot identify every person’s political preference.

Then write three sentences: one describing the detail, one interpreting it, one saying what the image alone cannot establish.

Common B1+ route: a 90 to 110-word museum label with two visual details, one contextual fact, one supported interpretation and one qualification.

Towards B2: explain how the title may create a tension between popular power and exclusion.

> **Answer key**
>
> Accept different details if the interpretation really follows from them. Possible answer: “Several figures appear to react differently to the announcement. This may suggest that the election creates both excitement and disappointment. However, the image alone cannot tell us exactly what every person thinks.”
>
> Possible label: “*The Verdict of the People* was painted by George Caleb Bingham in 1854 to 1855. A large crowd gathers in front of a courthouse to hear election results. In the foreground, one man waves his hat while others look dejected or argue, so the event appears lively and divided. The painting can be read as a celebration of popular power. However, according to the museum, the women on the balcony and the enslaved man on the left had no voice in government at the time. The title therefore raises a question: who counts as “the people”?” (104 words)

Expanding your vocabulary

Item	Meaning	Useful chunk
depict	represent in an image	depict a crowd
foreground / background	the part nearest the viewer / furthest away	in the foreground

Item	Meaning	Useful chunk
onlooker	a person watching an event	an onlooker watches
elated	extremely happy	appear elated
dejected	visibly unhappy	look dejected
suggest	indicate without proving	the detail suggests
excluded	not allowed to take part	excluded from voting

Productive core (use these in your own sentences): depict, foreground, background, suggest, appear, excluded.

Recognition or extension (understand them; use them if useful): elated, dejected, onlooker.

Quick exercise. Replace *show*, *watcher* and *very happy* with words from the table.

> **Answer key**
>
> depict, onlooker, elated.

WRITTEN RECORD

Bingham represents an election result as a public event with varied reactions. We must separate what we see, what a source tells us and what we interpret. The painting raises a central question: who is included in “the people”?

EXIT TICKET

Write one observation and one interpretation of the painting. Begin the second sentence with “This may suggest…”.

Homework

1. Finish the 90 to 110-word museum label (Exercise 1E).
2. Make three flashcards with the method on the flashcards page.
3. Prepare one question about how election results affect government.

Estimated time: 15 minutes.

Lesson 2. Why Midterms Matter

How can Congress limit presidential power?

Road map

Lesson of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes. Lesson 2 of 7. Minutes 52 to 55 stay free for collecting work, moving and the change of room.

1. Paired retrieval: the painting's political question 4 min (minutes 0 to 4)
2. Check homework; introduce Congress 4 min (minutes 4 to 8)
3. Read Source B (common reading) and complete Exercise 2A 8 min (minutes 8 to 16)
4. Exercise 2B; correct institutional misconceptions 8 min (minutes 16 to 24)
5. Passive-voice workshop, Exercise 2C 8 min (minutes 24 to 32)
6. Paired explanation for an exchange student, Exercise 2D 8 min (minutes 32 to 40)
7. Write a four-sentence explanation 4 min (minutes 40 to 44)
8. Written record 4 min (minutes 44 to 48)
9. Exit ticket: one power of each chamber 2 min (minutes 48 to 50)
10. Homework 2 min (minutes 50 to 52)

- **Written record.** Congress has two chambers; midterms can change congressional power without electing a president; a seat majority does not guarantee that every proposal passes.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each partner gives a 45-second reply to the exchange student (2D) and the other partner summarises it in their own words.
- **Homework for next lesson.** Write an 80 to 100-word reply to the exchange student with two passive constructions; make three flashcards, one contrasting *bill* and *law*.

Stopping point. Minute 44, after the four-sentence explanation.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If only eight working minutes remain, this replaces the unfinished plan; it is not added to it.

1. Minutes 0 to 2: each partner explains one power of Congress.
2. Minutes 2 to 5: write the first three sentences of the written record.
3. Minutes 5 to 7: record the homework.
4. Minute 7 to 8: correct "The Senate alone makes all laws."

Objectives

Explain the role of Congress and separate several institutional powers.

Language: passive voice, can, must, both, whereas.

SOURCE B · COMMON READING

Congress and the president

Student text, newly written from USAGov and the Constitution.

Congress has two chambers: the House of Representatives and the Senate. House members are elected every two years. Senators serve six-year terms, so only part of the Senate (about one third) is regularly elected every two years.

Midterm elections take place between presidential elections. They can change the balance of power in Congress without directly electing a new president.

For ordinary federal legislation, both chambers generally need to approve the same bill before it is presented to the president. The president may veto it. Congress can override a veto through the constitutionally required votes.

A president's party may therefore win the presidency but still face opposition in Congress. This can make negotiation necessary.

Sources: USAGov, Congressional elections and midterm elections · National Archives, the Constitution, transcript.

EXTENSION AND TEACHER REFERENCE

More powers, more thresholds

All 435 House seats are contested every two years. To override a veto, Congress needs a two-thirds vote in each chamber. The Senate considers many presidential nominations and gives advice and consent to treaties, which requires two thirds of the senators present. The House has the power to impeach; the Senate holds the trial.

With all 435 House seats filled, 218 is a majority of seats. In a full 100-seat Senate, 51 seats form a numerical majority. However, not every decision uses the same threshold, and the Vice President may break a tied Senate vote. Chamber control is not a guarantee that every proposal will pass.

These points stay available for interested students; they are not all compulsory recall items.

EXERCISE 2A

Build the institutional chart

Question	Answer
Which two chambers make up Congress?	
How long is a House term?	
How long is a Senate term?	
Are all Senate seats regularly contested together?	
Do midterms directly elect the president?	

> **Answer key**
>
> - The House of Representatives and the Senate.
> - Two years.
> - Six years.
> - No: about one third every two years.

- No.

EXERCISE 2B

Who can do what?

Match each power to **House**, **Senate**, **both chambers** or **president**. Items 3 to 5 use the extension box.

1. Veto a bill.
2. Approve ordinary legislation before it is presented to the president.
3. Impeach.
4. Hold an impeachment trial.
5. Consider many presidential nominations.
6. Override a presidential veto through the required votes.

Then explain why this statement is misleading: “Any party with 51 senators can automatically make every proposal become law.”

Answer key

1. President.
2. Both chambers.
3. House.
4. Senate.
5. Senate.
6. Both chambers.

The statement is misleading because lawmaking normally also involves the House and the president, and some Senate decisions need other procedural or constitutional thresholds.

EXERCISE 2C

Passive voice, with a reason

Transform the sentences.

1. Voters elect House members every two years.
2. Both chambers must approve the bill.
3. The Senate considers the nomination.
4. The president vetoed the bill.
5. Congress can override a veto.

Why the passive? In a news report, why might a journalist put *the bill* rather than *both chambers* at the start of sentence 2?

Answer key

1. House members are elected every two years.
2. The bill must be approved by both chambers.
3. The nomination is considered by the Senate.
4. The bill was vetoed by the president.

5. A veto can be overridden by Congress.

The report may be focusing on the bill and the stage it has reached, rather than on the people or institutions doing the action.

EXERCISE 2D

Mediation: answer an exchange student

An exchange student says: “The president won an election, so Congress has to accept the president’s plans.”

Give a 45-second reply with one institutional fact, one example of a limit and one qualification. Your partner then summarises your reply without copying its exact words.

Common B1+ route: explain why a president cannot simply turn every proposal into law; use one institutional example and one passive construction.

Towards B2: explain why congressional support may help a president without guaranteeing every policy outcome.

Answer key

Possible response: “Winning a presidential election does not give the president unlimited power. Congress has separate constitutional responsibilities. For example, a proposed law normally has to be approved by both chambers. The Senate also considers many presidential nominations. A president may find cooperation easier with the support of Congress, but support does not guarantee that every proposal will pass.”

Expanding your vocabulary

Item	Meaning	Useful chunk
chamber	one part of a legislature	both chambers
bill	a proposed law	approve a bill
approve	officially accept	approve the same bill
veto	a presidential rejection of a bill	veto a bill
majority	more than half	a majority of seats
negotiate	discuss to reach an agreement	negotiate with Congress
override	overcome through the required procedure	override a veto
oversight	checking the work of government	conduct oversight

Productive core (use these in your own sentences): chamber, bill, approve, veto, majority, negotiate.

Recognition or extension (understand them; use them if useful): override, nomination, oversight, impeachment.

Quick exercise. Complete: (1) A proposed law is a _____. (2) Congress may _____ a veto. (3) The House and the Senate are two _____.

> **Answer key**
>
> bill; override; chambers.

WRITTEN RECORD

Congress consists of the House and the Senate. Midterms can change congressional power without directly electing a new president. The chambers have shared and separate responsibilities. A seat majority does not guarantee that every proposal passes.

EXIT TICKET

Give one power of the House and one power of the Senate.

Homework

Write an 80 to 100-word reply to the exchange student in 2D. Include two passive constructions. Make three flashcards, including one that contrasts *bill* and *law*.

Lesson 3. Citizens, but Equally Represented?

What do Puerto Rico and Washington, D.C. reveal about federal representation?

Road map

Lesson of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes. Lesson 3 of 7. Minutes 52 to 55 stay free for collecting work, moving and the change of room.

1. Paired retrieval: one shared and one separate power of Congress 4 min (minutes 0 to 4)
2. Locate Puerto Rico and Washington, D.C.; introduce the question 4 min (minutes 4 to 8)
3. Read Source C; complete Exercise 3A 9 min (minutes 8 to 17)
4. Correct and discuss the limits of simplified statements 8 min (minutes 17 to 25)
5. Contrast and concession, Exercise 3B 8 min (minutes 25 to 33)
6. Paired explainer: repair the statements, Exercise 3C 7 min (minutes 33 to 40)
7. Draft the opening of the paragraph, Exercise 3D 4 min (minutes 40 to 44)
8. Written record 4 min (minutes 44 to 48)
9. Exit ticket: “Citizenship and residence are not the same because…” 2 min (minutes 48 to 50)
10. Homework 2 min (minutes 50 to 52)

- **Written record.** Puerto Rico and Washington, D.C. have federal representation, but not the same as states; we separate citizenship, residence and the powers of an office.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: in pairs, each partner repairs two misleading statements aloud (3C).
- **Homework for next lesson.** Finish the paragraph (3D), make three flashcards, write two sentences linking this lesson with Bingham’s painting.

Stopping point. Minute 44, after the opening of the paragraph.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If only eight working minutes remain, this replaces the unfinished plan; it is not added to it.

1. Minutes 0 to 2: each partner states one similarity and one difference.
2. Minutes 2 to 5: write a four-line comparison table.
3. Minutes 5 to 7: record the homework.
4. Minute 7 to 8: repair “Puerto Rico has no representation.”

Objectives

Separate citizenship, residence, representation and presidential voting.

Language: although, whereas, despite, can and cannot.

This lesson matches an objet d’étude named in the official programme for Première, axe 6: « Porto Rico : le 51e état ? »

SOURCE C

Different forms of representation

Student text, newly written from official institutional information.

1. Puerto Rico

Puerto Rico is a US territory, not a state. Its people elect a Resident Commissioner for a four-year term. The Resident Commissioner can introduce bills, take part in debates, and serve and vote on committees. However, the Resident Commissioner cannot vote when the full House takes its final vote on a bill. (*Final passage* means the final vote to approve a bill in the full House.) Puerto Rico has no senators.

2. Washington, D.C.

Washington, D.C. is a federal district, not a state. It has a delegate in the House but no senators. The Twenty-third Amendment, ratified in 1961, gives the district presidential electors: it has three. Puerto Rico has no presidential electors.

3. Why residence matters

For presidential voting, where a person lives matters. Puerto Rican identity alone does not tell us whether a person can vote in a presidential election: eligible US citizens from Puerto Rico who live in a state or in Washington, D.C. can vote there, under the rules of that place.

Congress has the constitutional power to admit new states. A discussion of Puerto Rico's future must also recognise that the island's residents do not all favour the same status.

Sources: Office of the Resident Commissioner, "What is a Resident Commissioner?" · National Archives, Amendments 11 to 27 · National Archives, the Constitution.

TEACHER'S NOTE

The original sequence gave a percentage for the 2024 status vote. It is not needed for this lesson. Do not reuse it without the exact official certification, its denominator and its date. The Resident Commissioner's official page adds that the office cannot vote for the Speaker of the House and represents over three million people: useful for a B2 extension question.

EXERCISE 3A

Compare

Feature	Puerto Rico	Washington, D.C.
State, territory or federal district?		
Senators?		
House representation?		
Presidential electors?		

Answer key

Feature	Puerto Rico	Washington, D.C.
Status	Territory	Federal district
Senators	None	None
House representation	Resident Commissioner	Delegate
Presidential electors	None	Three

EXERCISE 3B

Contrast and concession: choose, then explain

Complete with *although*, *whereas* or *despite*.

1. Washington, D.C. has presidential electors, _____ Puerto Rico does not.
2. _____ the Resident Commissioner has important responsibilities, the office has limits.
3. _____ having House representation, neither place has senators.
4. Rewrite with *despite*: “Although the two places have representatives in the House, they have no senators.”

Then answer: which sentence compares two arrangements? Which two introduce a contrast between an expectation and a limit?

Answer key

1. whereas.
2. Although.
3. Despite.
4. “Despite having representatives in the House, the two places have no senators.”

Sentence 1 compares two arrangements. Sentences 2 and 3 introduce a concession.

EXERCISE 3C

Repair the explanation (pairs, aloud)

1. Puerto Rico has no representation of any kind in Congress.
2. The Resident Commissioner cannot vote anywhere in Congress.
3. Anyone of Puerto Rican origin is barred from presidential voting.
4. Washington, D.C. and Puerto Rico have identical electoral arrangements.

Answer key

1. It has a Resident Commissioner.
2. The Resident Commissioner can vote in committees but not on final passage in the full House.
3. The broad claim confuses identity with residence and eligibility.
4. Washington, D.C. has presidential electors; Puerto Rico does not.

EXERCISE 3D

A balanced paragraph

Question: **What do Puerto Rico and Washington, D.C. show about different forms of federal representation?**

Common B1+ route: 110 to 140 words, two accurate comparisons, two connectors (one comparison, one concession), a careful conclusion.

Towards B2: explain why citizenship, residence and representation should not be treated as interchangeable ideas.

> **Answer key**
>
> Possible answer: “Citizenship does not always lead to the same form of federal representation. Puerto Rico and Washington, D.C. both lack senators, although both have representation in the House. Puerto Rico elects a Resident Commissioner who can take part in committee work but cannot vote on final passage in the full House. Washington, D.C. has three presidential electors, whereas Puerto Rico has none. However, it would be misleading to describe this only as a difference between groups of people. Residence matters: eligible US citizens from Puerto Rico living in a state or in Washington, D.C. can vote there. These examples show that citizenship and electoral arrangements must be kept apart.” (110 words)

Expanding your vocabulary

Item	Meaning	Useful chunk
citizen	a legal member of a country	a US citizen
resident	a person who lives in a place	residents of Puerto Rico
territory	an area that belongs to a country but is not a state	a US territory
representative	a person who speaks or acts for a group	elect a representative
delegate	a representative with a particular role in the House	a House delegate
final passage	the final vote to approve a bill	vote on final passage
statehood	the status of being a state	debate statehood
have a say	take part in a decision	have a say in legislation

Productive core (use these in your own sentences): citizen, resident, territory, representative, whereas, although.

Recognition or extension (understand them; use them if useful): Resident Commissioner, delegate, presidential elector, final passage, statehood (for the extension discussion).

Quick exercise. Explain the difference between “has no representative” and “has no vote on final passage”.

> **Answer key**
>
> The first denies representation altogether; the second names a specific limit on the powers of an existing representative.

WRITTEN RECORD

Puerto Rico and Washington, D.C. have federal representation, but not the same arrangements as states. Neither has senators. Their presidential-elector arrangements differ. We must separate citizenship, residence and the powers attached to a representative's office.

EXIT TICKET

Complete: "Citizenship and residence are not the same because…"

Homework

Finish Exercise 3D. Make three flashcards. Add two sentences linking this lesson with Bingham's painting, without claiming that the historical and present-day situations are identical.

Lesson 4. Images, Claims and Reported Speech

How can we tell evidence, interpretation and persuasion apart?

Road map

Lesson of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes. Lesson 4 of 7. Minutes 52 to 55 stay free for collecting work, moving and the change of room.

1. Paired comparison of Puerto Rico and Washington, D.C. 4 min (minutes 0 to 4)
2. Six-point midpoint check, Exercise 4A 6 min (minutes 4 to 10)
3. Immediate correction 4 min (minutes 10 to 14)
4. Observe *Stump Speaking* and read Source D 7 min (minutes 14 to 21)
5. Classify the statements, Exercise 4B 7 min (minutes 21 to 28)
6. Reported speech, Exercise 4C 7 min (minutes 28 to 35)
7. Candidate and reporter exchange, Exercise 4D 9 min (minutes 35 to 44)
8. Written record 4 min (minutes 44 to 48)
9. Exit ticket: one attributed statement 2 min (minutes 48 to 50)
10. Homework 2 min (minutes 50 to 52)

- **Written record.** Images and messages can inform and persuade at the same time; a promise is not an outcome; a cautious rewrite must not add new, unverified facts.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each partner plays the candidate and the reporter in 4D.
- **Homework for next lesson.** Using a teacher-approved election report, record its publisher, title, date and URL, paraphrase one factual claim and identify one interpretation or prediction; make two flashcards.

Stopping point. Minute 44, after both partners have acted as reporter.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If only eight working minutes remain, this replaces the unfinished plan; it is not added to it.

1. Minutes 0 to 2: each partner reports one invented classroom statement.
2. Minutes 2 to 5: write the written record.
3. Minutes 5 to 7: record the homework.
4. Minute 7 to 8: name one piece of evidence needed to test a promise.

Objectives

Analyse a second painting, report statements accurately and avoid inventing neutral-sounding facts.

Language: reported speech, attribution (according to…), cautious interpretation.

SOURCE D

Stump Speaking

Reference. George Caleb Bingham, *Stump Speaking*, 1853 to 1854, oil on canvas, Saint Louis Art Museum, accession 43:2001. Museum record.

Student text, newly written from the museum record.

A candidate addresses a rural crowd. Another man sits behind him with notes, waiting for his turn. The museum identifies the speaker as Erasmus Darwin Sappington, Bingham's opponent in a contested election.

The museum also explains that Bingham intended the painting to celebrate democratic elections for a wider national audience. This is a sourced interpretation of the artist's purpose. It should not be confused with something we can establish from the visible image alone.

A painting can therefore be an artistic construction, a historical source and a representation shaped by personal experience. It is not a neutral recording of everything that happened.

TEACHER EXPLANATION OR EXTENSION

According to the museum, Bingham ran as a Whig candidate for the Missouri state legislature in 1846. He won by three votes, but the result was contested and the seat was given to his opponent, Sappington. Keep this story out of the compulsory reading; use it to ask B2 students how personal experience may shape a painting.

EXERCISE 4A

Midpoint check · six points

One point each.

1. Give the artist of *The Verdict of the People*.
2. Name the two chambers of Congress.
3. Which chamber considers many presidential nominations?
4. Give one power of Puerto Rico's Resident Commissioner.
5. Which has presidential electors: Puerto Rico or Washington, D.C.?
6. Complete: "The bill must _____ approved by both chambers."

> **Answer key**
>
> 1. George Caleb Bingham.
> 2. The House of Representatives and the Senate.
> 3. The Senate.
> 4. Introduce bills, take part in debate, or serve and vote on committees.
> 5. Washington, D.C.
> 6. be.

EXERCISE 4B

Classify the statement, not just its tone

V: verifiable institutional statement. **J**: judgement. **P**: prediction or promise. **A**: attributed interpretation. Some statements may need a different label: say why.

1. The House has 435 voting seats.
2. This is the only candidate who cares about ordinary people.
3. The proposal will solve the problem.
4. According to the museum, Bingham intended a broader celebration of elections.

5. The painting contains several figures listening to a speaker.
6. The election result proves that every voter supports the winning party's entire programme.

Then repair statement 6 without inventing a result.

> **Answer key**
>
> 1. V.
> 2. J.
> 3. P.
> 4. A.
> 5. A visual description that anyone can check in the painting.
> 6. An unsupported interpretation.
>
> Possible repair: "The result identifies the winner under the election rules. It does not by itself show agreement with every policy."

EXERCISE 4C

Reported speech

These are invented classroom statements, not historical quotations.

Common B1+ route

1. A fictional candidate says: "I support the proposal." Begin: *Yesterday, the candidate said…*
2. Two fictional campaigners say: "We will publish the cost." Begin: *They told the audience…*

Towards B2

1. A fictional reporter asks me: "Did you check the source?" Begin: *The reporter asked me…*
2. A fictional student says: "The source is incomplete." Begin: *The student explained…*
3. Explain why a reporter might keep the present tense when describing a claim that is still current.

> **Answer key**
>
> 1. "…that they supported the proposal."
> 2. "…that they would publish the cost."
> 3. "…if (or whether) I had checked the source."
> 4. "…that the source was incomplete."
> 5. A present-tense report can be justified when the reporter deliberately presents the statement as still true. The choice should keep the intended meaning.
>
> Accept a suitable pronoun (he, she, they). Discuss justified alternatives without backshift rather than marking them wrong automatically.

EXERCISE 4D

Candidate and reporter (pairs)

Partner A gives a 30-second fictional school-council message with one proposal, one reason and one promise.

Partner B reports it and asks: “What evidence would help us evaluate that promise?” Swap roles.

Do not impersonate a real politician or invent historical speech.

> **Answer key**
>
> - The report keeps the original meaning.
> - A promise is not presented as an achieved result.
> - The follow-up question asks for relevant evidence.
> - Both students take both roles.

EXERCISE 4E · MAIN PRODUCTION

Accurate and persuasive?

Can a message contain accurate information and still try to persuade? Explain with one classroom example.

Common B1+ route: four connected sentences.

Towards B2: explain how selection or emphasis can shape interpretation even when the stated information is accurate.

> **Answer key**
>
> Possible answer: “A message can give accurate information and still try to persuade. It may select the most favourable details and leave other relevant information out. For example, a campaign message may describe a proposal without explaining its cost. We therefore need to examine both accuracy and selection.”

Expanding your vocabulary

Item	Meaning	Useful chunk
claim	a statement presented as true	make a claim
promise	a commitment about future action	make a promise
evidence	information that supports or challenges a claim	evidence for a claim
according to	as stated by	according to the museum
persuade	make someone believe or do something	try to persuade voters
verify	check accuracy	verify a statement
framing	the way an issue is presented	examine the framing

Productive core (use these in your own sentences): claim, promise, evidence, according to, persuade, verify.

Recognition or extension (understand them; use them if useful): attribution, framing, soundbite, spin.

Quick exercise. Choose the best verb: “We should *describe / verify* whether the figure matches the original source.”

> **Answer key**
>
> verify.

WRITTEN RECORD

Images and messages can inform and persuade at the same time. We must identify who makes a claim and what supports it. A promise is not an outcome. A cautious rewrite must not introduce new, unverified facts.

EXIT TICKET

Write one attributed statement about *Stump Speaking*, starting with “According to the museum,…”.

Homework

Using a teacher-approved election report (or the printed report supplied by your teacher):

1. Record the publisher, title, date and URL.
2. Paraphrase one factual claim.
3. Identify one interpretation or prediction.
4. Do not reproduce the article in full.

Make two flashcards.

Lesson 5. Results: Establish, Date and Qualify

What can we responsibly say about the election results?

Road map

Lesson of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes. Lesson 5 of 7. Minutes 52 to 55 stay free for collecting work, moving and the change of room.

1. Partners share one sourced homework claim 4 min (minutes 0 to 4)
2. Result status and the source packet 5 min (minutes 4 to 9)
3. Source A research, Exercise 5A 9 min (minutes 9 to 18)
4. Source B comparison, Exercise 5B 9 min (minutes 18 to 27)
5. Teacher correction of categories and discrepancies 6 min (minutes 27 to 33)
6. Language practice, Exercise 5C 5 min (minutes 33 to 38)
7. Paired 60-second bulletins, Exercise 5D 6 min (minutes 38 to 44)
8. Written record and dated finding 4 min (minutes 44 to 48)
9. Exit ticket: “We can establish… / We cannot yet establish…” 2 min (minutes 48 to 50)
10. Homework 2 min (minutes 50 to 52)

- **Written record.** “As of [date and time], according to [source], we can establish [finding]. The information is described as [status]. We cannot yet establish [limit].”
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each partner gives a 60-second bulletin with four required moves (5D).
- **Homework for next lesson.** Write a 120 to 150-word bulletin from the class’s verified evidence, with source and date, one past simple sentence, one present perfect sentence and one qualification.

Stopping point. Minute 44, after the paired bulletins.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If only eight working minutes remain, this replaces the unfinished plan; it is not added to it.

1. Minutes 0 to 2: each student states one sourced finding or one unresolved question.
2. Minutes 2 to 5: complete the four-line written record.
3. Minutes 5 to 7: record the homework.
4. Minute 7 to 8: check that every number has a source and a category.

Objectives

Gather comparable information, identify the status of a result and produce a qualified bulletin.

Language: past simple, present perfect, attribution and uncertainty.

NO RESULT IS GIVEN HERE

This page does not give any 2026 winner, seat total, gain or loss. The midterm elections took place on 3 November 2026. You establish the results yourselves from dated, identifiable sources. If the evidence is missing or incomplete, the right answer is a qualified statement, not an invented figure.

TEACHER PREPARATION

Do not begin with unrestricted searching across an untested list of links. Prepare a packet:

- **Source A:** one accessible news report or results tracker.
- **Source B:** a second report with an identifiable publisher and update time.
- **Source C:** a state election-office page to check one selected race. Directory: USAGov, state election offices.

Record the exact working URL and access date of each (note the time zone: Europe/Paris and US Eastern time differ). Keep offline copies or factual summaries with full references. Do not use a current membership list of Congress as if it were a list of newly elected members: keep the outgoing Congress, the election outcomes and the incoming Congress separate. The reading level of real reports cannot be judged before they are chosen: a short explanatory report and a dense interactive tracker do not make the same demand.

Common B1+ route: one chamber, two teacher-selected sources, one question, a partly completed source log. Suggested question: “As of the source update, what can we establish about projected control of this chamber?” **Towards B2:** compare the second chamber, explain a category difference, investigate why two sources seem to disagree.

SOURCE E

Reading a results page

Original classroom guidance.

A media call is an organisation’s assessment of who has won a race. It is not the same act as legal certification.

Reported vote totals may be incomplete. A source may count projected winners, races not yet called, seats not contested that year or caucus alignments. Read the labels before comparing figures.

For the Senate, the number of races won this year is not the same as the total make-up of the chamber: many senators are continuing their terms.

A newer number is not automatically comparable with an older one. First check whether both sources count the same thing.

Category	Meaning
Called	A news organisation has assessed the winner.
Not yet called	That organisation has not assessed a winner.
Projected chamber control	The source’s assessment of which party will control the chamber.
Certified	Formally confirmed through the legal process.

EXERCISE 5A

Complete the source log

Field	Source A	Source B
Publisher		

Field	Source A	Source B
Exact page title		
URL		
Published or updated		
Accessed: date, time and time zone		
House or Senate?		
What exactly is counted?		
Called, projected, unofficial or certified?		

> **Answer key**
>
> There is no fixed answer: it depends on the pages in your packet. A good log names the actual page, records its date and status, separates House results from Senate make-up and says exactly what is counted. A reliable-looking source and a timestamp are necessary, but not sufficient: a figure can still be misread.

EXERCISE 5B

Build a defensible results table

Leave a cell blank if you cannot establish it.

Item	Finding	Source and time	Qualification
House seats called or reported for each party			
House races not yet called			
Projected incoming House control, if established			
Projected incoming Senate make-up			
How independents or caucus alignments are classified			
One selected race checked against an official page			

Then answer:

1. Do the sources agree?
2. If not, are they counting the same category?
3. Is one page older?
4. Does either page explain its method?
5. What can you state confidently?
6. What remains uncertain?

> **Answer key**
>
> There is no fixed numerical answer. A satisfactory response separates House results from Senate make-up, explains category differences and does not infer a result from missing data. If chamber control is not

established in your sources, the correct answer is “not established as of [time]”.

EXERCISE 5C

Tenses and status

These are language-practice sentences, not election claims. Choose and justify the tense.

1. “We *checked / have checked* the page at 10 a.m. yesterday.”
2. “The page *changed / has changed* several times since our first visit.”
3. “The report *was published / has been published* on Monday.”
4. We _____ not yet _____ a certification notice. *(find)*
5. Rewrite responsibly: “The result is final because a television channel announced a winner.”

Optional B2 extension, only with a verified calculation: “If the party had won [verified number] more seats, it would have reached [verified threshold].” Do not complete it with invented figures; it is not required in the bulletins.

Answer key

1. checked: a finished action at a finished past time.
2. has changed: a period continuing to the present.
3. was published: a specific finished past occasion.
4. have … found.
5. “The channel has called the race, but that does not by itself show that the result has been legally certified.”

Then write two sentences about your own research process: this tests tense choice without any invented election claim.

EXERCISE 5D

News bulletin (pairs, 60 seconds each)

Use four required moves:

1. “Our source is…”
2. “Updated on…, it reports…”
3. “This means we can say…”
4. “However, we cannot yet say…”

If chamber control is not established, say so.

Answer key

Model frame: “According to [publisher], updated at [time and date], [verified finding]. The page describes this as [status]. This may affect [institutional consequence]. However, we cannot yet conclude [limit], because [reason].” The brackets must be completed from evidence or left unresolved.

Expanding your vocabulary

Item	Meaning	Useful chunk
source	where information comes from	name your source
update	newer information added to a page	the latest update
call a race	announce a winner through a media decision	the network called the race
certify	formally confirm through the legal process	certify the results
outstanding	not yet resolved	outstanding races
incoming / outgoing	about to take office / about to leave office	the incoming Congress
caucus	a group of members who work together	caucus with a party
gain / loss	increase / decrease against a defined starting point	a net gain

Productive core (use these in your own sentences): source, update, report, call a race, result, not yet established.

Recognition or extension (understand them; use them if useful): certification, incoming, outgoing, caucus alignment, comparison baseline.

Quick exercise. Why is “The party gained seats” incomplete?

> **Answer key**
>
> We need the chamber, the number, the source, the status and the starting point of the comparison.

WRITTEN RECORD

As of _____, according to _____, we can establish _____. The information is described as _____. We cannot yet establish _____. A media call, a reported count and legal certification are not the same thing.

EXIT TICKET

Complete both: “We can establish…” and “We cannot yet establish…”.

Homework

Write a 120 to 150-word bulletin from the class’s verified evidence. Include the source and date, one past simple sentence, one present perfect sentence where appropriate and one qualification. If the results are still unresolved, explain the uncertainty. Do not fill gaps by guessing.

Lesson 6. Beyond US Borders

Why might neighbouring countries care about who sits in Congress?

Road map

Lesson of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes. Lesson 6 of 7. Minutes 52 to 55 stay free for collecting work, moving and the change of room.

1. Paired update from the results log 4 min (minutes 0 to 4)
2. Locate Canada, Mexico and two Caribbean places 4 min (minutes 4 to 8)
3. Read Source F; complete Exercise 6A 7 min (minutes 8 to 15)
4. Two teacher readings of Source G; complete Exercise 6B 7 min (minutes 15 to 22)
5. Compare and correct 7 min (minutes 22 to 29)
6. Conditional workshop, Exercise 6C 7 min (minutes 29 to 36)
7. Role-card preparation and paired challenge, Exercise 6D 8 min (minutes 36 to 44)
8. Written record 4 min (minutes 44 to 48)
9. Exit ticket: one fact and one hypothesis 2 min (minutes 48 to 50)
10. Homework 2 min (minutes 50 to 52)

- **Written record.** US elections matter beyond US borders, but consequences are not automatic: connect a verified change to a possible route to a decision and state a limit.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each partner presents a role card and answers the challenge “Which part is established, and which part is your interpretation?”
- **Homework for next lesson.** Prepare the radio discussion: role card, 45-second opening, two questions, a keyword card of 40 words maximum, draft of the briefing note.

Stopping point. Minute 44, after the role-card exchange.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If only eight working minutes remain, this replaces the unfinished plan; it is not added to it.

1. Minutes 0 to 2: each partner gives one fact and one hypothesis.
2. Minutes 2 to 5: complete the written record.
3. Minutes 5 to 7: record the homework.
4. Minute 7 to 8: hand in a role card with two sourced facts.

Objectives

Connect the powers of Congress with cross-border interests while separating established facts from predictions.

Language: if + present with may, might, could; second conditional as an extension.

SOURCE F

Trade and political power

Student text, newly written from the Office of the US Trade Representative and the Constitution.

The United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement, or USMCA, entered into force on 1 July 2020. It concerns trade between the three countries and replaced NAFTA.

The US Constitution gives Congress powers over foreign commerce and over taxes and duties. However, the effects of an election are not automatic. The president, existing laws, negotiations and decisions by other countries also matter.

Canada and Mexico may therefore follow congressional elections, because changes in political support can affect the debate over trade. Other places in the Americas may focus on different issues. We need evidence before claiming that a whole country shares one concern.

Sources: USTR, United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement · National Archives, the Constitution.

TEACHER'S NOTE

The original sequence gave a specific account of the July 2026 USMCA joint review. The background sources above do not establish that outcome. If you add it, give the exact dated official statement and distinguish extension, continued operation and termination. A review is not an automatic expiry.

EXERCISE 6A

Read and distinguish

Label each statement: **fact**, **hypothesis** or **unsupported certainty**.

1. USMCA entered into force on 1 July 2020.
2. A new majority in Congress might influence trade debates.
3. Every Canadian voter has the same view of US trade policy.
4. Congress has constitutional powers over foreign commerce.
5. An election result automatically fixes future prices.

> **Answer key**
>
> 1. Fact.
> 2. Hypothesis.
> 3. Unsupported certainty.
> 4. Fact.
> 5. Unsupported certainty.

SOURCE G · LISTENING

A reporter's method

Original classroom script, read twice by the teacher. It is not an authentic broadcast. First listening: books closed, answer questions 1 and 2. Second listening: answer questions 3 to 5. The script is printed at the bottom of this page for the correction and for students working alone.

EXERCISE 6B

Listening

First listening

1. Does the speaker say elections are unimportant?
2. What distinction is the main message?

Second listening

3. What three steps should the reporter follow?
4. Name two other actors or factors.
5. Which words signal uncertainty?

> **Answer key**
>
> 1. No.
> 2. The difference between what has changed and what may happen next.
> 3. Explain the change in Congress; explain how it could affect a decision; say what is still uncertain.
> 4. The president, existing laws and the other countries.
> 5. could, uncertain, may.

EXERCISE 6C

Hypotheses

Common B1+ route (if + present, may/might/could)

1. If Congress _____ the proposal, the debate _____ change. *(oppose, might)*
2. If a tariff increases import costs, prices _____ rise. *(possibility, not certainty)*
3. Rewrite cautiously: “If the opposition wins a chamber, all trade agreements will end.”

Towards B2 (second conditional)

4. If I {G} a reporter, I {G} ask for the original evidence. *(be, would)*
5. Write your own: “If I were reporting from Canada, I would…”

> **Answer key**
>
> 1. opposes; might.
> 2. may, might or could.
> 3. “If the opposition wins a chamber, it may affect support for some trade measures. That result would not by itself show that trade agreements will end.”
> 4. were; would.
> 5. Example: “If I were reporting from Canada, I would ask how the proposal could affect businesses.”
>
> Counterfactual inversion (*Had the party won…*) is left out of this lesson on purpose: students need the time to prepare the final task.

EXERCISE 6D

Build a role card

Choose a role: Washington political reporter, Canadian or Mexican business reporter, Puerto Rico reporter, host.

My contribution	My notes
Two verified facts	
The source of each fact	
One reasonable hypothesis	
How could this lead to the possible consequence?	
One limit	
One question for another speaker	

A partner challenges the card: “Which part is established, and which part is your interpretation?”

> **Answer key**
>
> - the facts match their sources;
> - the hypothesis is labelled as a hypothesis;
> - the route from fact to consequence is explained;
> - the speaker states a limit.
>
> Accept different perspectives if they meet these criteria. Do not accept a national stereotype as a substitute for evidence.

Expanding your vocabulary

Item	Meaning	Useful chunk
trade	buying and selling between countries	trade between neighbours
trading partner	a country involved in trade with another	a major trading partner
tariff	a tax on imported goods	impose a tariff
agreement	an arrangement accepted by the parties	a trade agreement
affect	influence or change	affect prices
uncertain	not securely known	the outcome is uncertain
ripple effect	consequences that spread beyond the first event	a regional ripple effect
mechanism	the process connecting a cause and an effect	explain the mechanism

Productive core (use these in your own sentences): trade, trading partner, tariff, agreement, affect, uncertain.

Recognition or extension (understand them; use them if useful): negotiation, ripple effect, mechanism, leverage.

Quick exercise. Complete: “An election may have a _____ effect, but a reporter must explain the _____ rather than simply predict an outcome.”

> **Answer key**
>
> ripple; mechanism.

WRITTEN RECORD

US elections matter beyond US borders, but consequences are not automatic. A responsible explanation connects a verified development to a possible route to a decision and states a limit. We must separate established facts from hypotheses.

EXIT TICKET

Write one fact and one hypothesis about US trade with Canada or Mexico.

Homework

1. Complete your role card.
2. Prepare a 45-second opening contribution.
3. Write two questions for other speakers.
4. Bring a keyword card of no more than 40 words (source references not included).
5. Draft your individual briefing note (see Lesson 7).

SOURCE G · SCRIPT FOR THE CORRECTION

A US election can matter to Canada and Mexico, but an election result does not immediately change every trade rule. First, a reporter should explain what has changed in Congress. Next, the reporter should explain how this could affect a decision, for example through a new law. Finally, the reporter should say what is still uncertain. Congress is not the only actor. The president, existing laws and the other countries also matter. A careful report therefore separates what has happened from what may happen next.

Lesson 7. The Cross-Border Radio Discussion

What can elections change, and what should responsible reporting avoid claiming?

Road map

Lesson of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes. Lesson 7 of 7. Minutes 52 to 55 stay free for collecting work, moving and the change of room.

1. Paired opening: each student gives a sourced fact and its limit 4 min (minutes 0 to 4)
2. The task and the assessment criteria 4 min (minutes 4 to 8)
3. Accuracy audit, Exercise 7A 6 min (minutes 8 to 14)
4. Rehearse openings; check speaking distribution 6 min (minutes 14 to 20)
5. Eight-minute radio discussion in simultaneous groups 8 min (minutes 20 to 28)
6. Peer feedback and individual clarification questions 6 min (minutes 28 to 34)
7. Repeat a selected section with improved interaction 6 min (minutes 34 to 40)
8. Complete and hand in the individual briefing note 4 min (minutes 40 to 44)
9. Written self-assessment 4 min (minutes 44 to 48)
10. Exit ticket: one claim improved through qualification 2 min (minutes 48 to 50)
11. Homework for the next English lesson 2 min (minutes 50 to 52)

- **Written record.** The five-line self-assessment: one fact I explained accurately, one source I used, one question I answered, one claim I qualified, my next language target.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks: each group member has a protected opening, at least one question or answer in the discussion and one qualification in the final round.
- **Homework for next lesson.** Revise one paragraph of the briefing note and explain the revision in two sentences; review six flashcards; write one rule for checking claims on another topic.

Stopping point. Minute 44, after the briefing notes have been handed in.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If only eight working minutes remain, this replaces the unfinished plan; it is not added to it.

1. Minutes 0 to 3: each student gives a 30-second role contribution in their group.
2. Minutes 3 to 5: complete the written self-assessment.
3. Minutes 5 to 7: hand in the briefing note and record the homework.
4. Minute 7 to 8: the teacher checks the participation roster. A shortened performance is formative unless enough individual evidence has been collected.

Objectives

Combine cultural analysis, institutional knowledge and source-based reasoning in an interactive discussion.

Language: turn-taking, concession, clarification and synthesis.

Final task

In groups of four, produce an eight-minute radio discussion in English for a Canadian student audience: **The Verdict of the People: What Can US Elections Change at Home and Across Borders?**

Your audience knows little about US institutions. Do not read a complete script: use keyword cards and source notes. Use Bingham's painting as an opening cultural reference, verified election information with its date and status, accurate institutional explanations, Puerto Rico as an example of unequal federal representation and a carefully qualified discussion of cross-border consequences.

Common B1+ route, for every student: give two accurate facts relevant to your role; identify at least one source; explain why one fact matters; ask or answer one question; state one limit.

Towards B2: an unprepared follow-up; a response to a counterargument; a comparison between two sources; a reformulation that corrects another speaker's misunderstanding.

Role	Responsibilities
Host	Explain the painting's relevance; ask at least two real questions; reformulate one answer; distinguish one established finding from one hypothesis; summarise. The host is not only a timekeeper.
Washington reporter	Present verified election information and explain the powers of Congress.
Canadian or Mexican business reporter	Explain one cross-border issue, how it could lead to a consequence, and a limit.
Puerto Rico reporter	Explain representation and prevent a misleading generalisation.

Eight-minute running order

Time	Contribution
0:00 to 0:40	Host: painting, programme question and a reminder about the status of sources.
0:40 to 1:30	Washington reporter.
1:30 to 2:20	Business reporter.
2:20 to 3:10	Puerto Rico reporter.
3:10 to 5:50	Discussion led by the host: each participant asks or answers at least one question.
5:50 to 7:20	Final round: each participant gives one qualification or one unresolved question.
7:20 to 8:00	Host summarises what is established and what remains uncertain.

Group of three: combine the host and Washington roles and reduce the discussion to six minutes. Group of five: add a source-checking reporter and keep the openings shorter.

EXERCISE 7A

Accuracy audit

Correct these statements before the discussion.

1. Midterms directly replace the president.

2. The Senate alone approves all ordinary legislation.
3. Puerto Rico has no representative.
4. A media call is the same as certification.
5. The painting is a neutral photograph of an election.
6. A congressional result automatically decides the next trade policy.

> **Answer key**
>
> 1. They elect Congress; they do not directly elect a new president.
> 2. Ordinary legislation generally needs both chambers and presentation to the president.
> 3. It has a Resident Commissioner with specific powers and limits.
> 4. A media call and legal certification are different acts.
> 5. It is an artistic representation that needs interpretation.
> 6. It may affect the political context, but the policy outcome needs further evidence.

EXERCISE 7B

Choose a useful connector

Use: however, nevertheless, moreover, therefore.

1. The two places share some features; _____, their presidential-elector arrangements differ.
2. The report is recent. _____, its categories must still be checked.
3. The Senate considers nominations. _____, it has responsibilities concerning treaties.
4. We do not have certification evidence. _____, we should not describe the result as certified.

> **Answer key**
>
> 1. however.
> 2. Nevertheless.
> 3. Moreover.
> 4. Therefore.
>
> Accept alternatives that give the intended logical link.

EXERCISE 7C

Repair the interaction

Rewrite each response politely and usefully.

1. “That is stupid.”
2. “You are wrong about everything.”
3. “I do not know, so I will guess.”
4. “That proves what everybody thinks.”

> **Answer key**
>
> 1. “I am not convinced by that argument. What evidence supports it?”
> 2. “I think we are using different categories. Which figure are you referring to?”
> 3. “I cannot establish that from our sources.”

4. “That identifies an outcome, but it does not establish every voter’s motivation.”

EXERCISE 7D

Individual briefing note

Common B1+ route, 140 to 170 words, written for your role: introduce your role’s question; explain two sourced facts; give one implication; state one limit; connect briefly to the driving question of the sequence. Use your own words and list your sources separately.

Towards B2: integrate a counterpoint or compare two interpretations.

Answer key

No single model answer should supply election results. Check that each factual statement matches the student’s source log and that the cross-border consequence is presented as a hypothesis, not an established outcome. The word range is a classroom planning choice, not a CEFR threshold.

Expanding your vocabulary

Function	Useful language
Introduce evidence	“According to the source, updated on…”
Clarify	“Do you mean the outgoing or the incoming Congress?”
Distinguish	“That is a projection rather than a certified result.”
Concede	“That is a reasonable point; however…”
Identify uncertainty	“Our sources do not establish that.”
Summarise	“We agree on the rule, but the consequence is still uncertain.”

Quick exercise. Which expression would you use when a speaker mixes up the Congress elected in November 2026 and the one sitting before January 2027?

Answer key

“Do you mean the outgoing or the incoming Congress?”

WRITTEN RECORD · SELF-ASSESSMENT

- One fact I explained accurately was…
- One source I used was…
- One question I answered was…
- One claim I qualified was…
- My next language target is…

EXIT TICKET

Write one claim from today, then improve it with a qualification.

Homework for the next English lesson

1. Revise one paragraph of your briefing note.
2. Explain the revision in two sentences.
3. Review six flashcards.
4. Write one rule for checking claims that you could use on another topic.

Marking grids: see the assessment page.

Assessment

An individual oral grid and a written grid, each out of 20.

Oral task · individual grid, /20

Criterion	Maximum	Evidence
Cultural and institutional accuracy	4	Accurate explanation of documents, powers and representation.
Use of sources and qualification	4	Identifiable evidence; date and status; a real limit.
Interaction and mediation	4	Asks, answers, listens and reformulates for the audience.
Organisation and fluency	4	Clear contribution; logical progression; manageable pauses.
Language and intelligibility	4	Suitable range, understandable pronunciation and sufficient control.

For each criterion:

- 4: secure, effective and independent.
- 3: generally effective, with minor lapses.
- 2: partly effective, with support or recurring difficulty.
- 1: limited assessable evidence.
- 0: no assessable evidence.

These are classroom descriptors, not an automatic CEFR conversion.

Secure common performance or towards B2?

Criterion	Secure common performance (B1+)	Evidence towards B2
Explanation	Clear, connected and supported by relevant facts.	More precise qualification and comparison.
Interaction	Answers a question and responds appropriately.	Handles an unexpected challenge or develops another speaker's point.
Sources	Identifies evidence accurately.	Explains why the evidence supports one claim but not another.
Language	Sufficient range; errors do not prevent understanding.	More flexible reformulation and greater control.

Do not award a higher level simply because a student uses *nevertheless* or a complex conditional. An eight-minute group discussion is not eight minutes of individual speech: each student's contribution is assessed separately.

Organising the oral assessment

Simultaneous discussions guarantee speaking time, but one teacher cannot reliably grade every student at once. Choose one arrangement before teaching:

- record groups using school-approved procedures, then assess afterwards;

- assess selected groups in Lesson 7 and the other groups during later independent work;
- keep the group discussion formative and assess the individual written note.

Peer ticks do not replace sufficient teacher evidence.

Written briefing note · /20

Criterion	Maximum
Meets the audience and task requirements	4
Accurate cultural and institutional information	4
Suitable sources and qualifications	4
Clear organisation and logical links	4
Range and control of language	4

Do not require every grammar structure taught in the sequence. Assess whether students choose language that serves their meaning. No model answer supplies election results: check each factual statement against the student's source log.

Student self-check before handing in

- Every number has a source, a time, a category and a status.
- I have not inferred a result from an outdated list of members.
- My cross-border consequence is presented as a hypothesis.
- I mention Bingham, two institutional or representation facts and one limit.

Expanding your vocabulary: student-made flashcards

There is no ready-made deck. You make your own cards; the vocabulary tables in each lesson are selection banks, not finished packs to copy.

The method

Step 1. Choose a useful difficulty

Choose a word, chunk or distinction that you misunderstood, could recognise but not use, or need for the final discussion. Examples: *override a veto*, *whereas*, *called* versus *certified*.

Step 2. Write a retrieval prompt on the front

The front must make you find something. Weak front: “Congress = Congress.” Better front: “Complete: Congress can _____ a presidential veto.”

Step 3. Build the back

1. the target word or chunk;
2. a short definition in English;
3. your own accurate example;
4. a pronunciation or stress cue if helpful;
5. the source or lesson;
6. a warning against one common error.

Step 4. Test before turning

Look at the front. Say the answer. Write or spell the difficult part. Use it in a sentence. Only then turn the card.

Step 5. Sort and review

Three piles: **not yet secure**, **correct with effort**, **easy today**. Suggested review: the next day, three days later, one week later. Move cards according to your results; do not keep reviewing only the easy ones.

Step 6. Improve the card

If you fail a card again and again, shorten the prompt, add a useful contrast or replace an unclear example.

One distinction card per lesson

At least one card per lesson should test a relationship, not just a definition:

- Lesson 1: description versus interpretation;
- Lesson 2: bill versus law;
- Lesson 3: citizen versus resident;
- Lesson 4: promise versus outcome;
- Lesson 5: media call versus certification;
- Lesson 6: fact versus possible consequence;

- Lesson 7: outgoing versus incoming Congress.

Model cards

Front	Back
Complete: Congress can _____ a presidential veto.	**override.** Meaning: overcome the veto through the votes required by the Constitution. Example: A veto can be overridden by Congress. Lesson 2. Warning: a simple seat majority is not the veto-override threshold (two thirds in each chamber).
Link the contrast: Washington, D.C. has electors, _____ Puerto Rico does not.	**whereas.** Example: Washington, D.C. has presidential electors, whereas Puerto Rico does not. Lesson 3.
Does “a news organisation called the race” mean “the result has been legally certified”?	**No.** A media call and legal certification are different acts. Example: The race has been called, but we have not established certification. Lesson 5.
Make the claim cautious: “The election will determine every trade outcome.”	The election **may affect** trade debates, but it will not by itself determine every outcome. Lesson 6.

Blank template

Front	Back
Retrieval question:	Target chunk:
Gap sentence:	Meaning in English:
	My example:
	Pronunciation cue:
	Source or lesson:
	Common error to avoid:
	Review dates and results:

Flashcard quality check

- Does the front test retrieval?
- Is the answer accurate?
- Does the example make sense?
- Have I avoided putting the full answer on the front?
- Can I use the item in a new sentence?

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